

It's Friday night and Lucie Hilin is passing go. The 18-year-old sociology student is an hour into a game of Monopoly with four of her uni mates. The banknotes are crusty with Cheezels crumbs and there's Thai takeaway on its way. They aren't toasting the purchase of every property with tequila. Nor are they recovering from an epic two-day hangover. It's a refreshingly different Friday from those gen X-ers would have enjoyed as students, when binge-drinking was considered a competitive sport.

Now, Australia's drinking culture is in flux, and young women are leading the sober charge. According to the latest National Drug Strategy Household Survey, the percentage of women aged 18-24, previously the group most likely to drink more than two or more standard drinks a day on average, has dropped from 20 per cent in 2007 to 12.8 per cent in 2016, with women in their 50s now outranking them as the group most likely to drink at risky levels. In 2018, a study by La Trobe University found that young adults aged between 24 and 29 are most likely to have recently reduced their intake, while women are twice as likely as men to quit booze.

The abstinence trend has left the \$15.5 billion Australian alcohol market both shaken and stirred. Its biggest players are plunging millions into low- and no-alcohol beverages in an attempt to cash in on the dry dollar, while start-ups producing high-quality zero-proof spirits and craft brews are multiplying rapidly.

Sober curiosity is nothing new, but the latest data suggests that interest has evolved into something more decisive. While millennials appear to be drinking much more mindfully, the next generation – gen Z, broadly defined as those born between 1995 and 2015 – seems to be opting out altogether. According to a report by Deakin University, Aussie teenagers are increasingly turning away from alcohol, so much so they've been dubbed "the sober generation".

So, if the younger generations aren't bookmarking their 20s by day-drinking until it seems cute to hijack a supermarket trolley, what are they doing? And what does this mean for the nation's health?

* Downing drinks

The big reason for the booze downturn is pretty wholesome at heart: wellness. "When we consider the younger generation, there seems to be a great deal of awareness about mental health and wellbeing, and the ways in which they need to look after themselves to stay mentally and physically well," says Briony Leo, psychologist and health coach at alcohol behaviour change organisation Hello Sunday Morning. "There is a focus on authenticity and being their 'best selves', and some of the things associated with regular and heavy drinking, such as health issues, spending money, misadventure and taking risks, may not appeal so much to them."

High-profile role models like Kayla Itsines epitomise the new health-conscious non-drinker. The fitness queen recently revealed on Instagram that she "just doesn't

enjoy" alcohol, and told her followers it was possible to be confident without the Dutch courage. Meanwhile, supermodel Jess Hart celebrated her 12-month sobriety anniversary in June last year, explaining that she "wanted to know what the best version of myself looked like".

Health was the trigger for 30-year-old Christina DeLay when she decided to quit. Her work as an IT consultant saw her drinking four or five nights a week, and it was taking its toll. "I started to get IBS and it was really affecting my mental health as well," she says. "I didn't feel great after I had alcohol, even if I just had one drink, so it wasn't worth it for me. I'd rather feel good than have a glass or two and feel a bit average the next day."

In the ultimate millennial fairytale, her focus on wellbeing even led to a successful business. Sick of sipping sugary soft drinks or soda water when socialising sober, Christina co-founded Altina Drinks, a range of sophisticated mocktails that make abstaining less of a sugar rush. It's the kind of pour you might find at, say, a Fancy Free pop-up bar (which have appeared everywhere from Melbourne to Brisbane), where two thirds of the cocktail list is low or alcohol-free, or a meeting of sober social group Untoxicated.

* Rise and grind

While booting booze in the name of wellness is – clearly – a good thing, it's important to note that not all routes to no-liquor living are quite so healthy. Among the positive factors, there are also pernicious pressures pushing young people away from drinking – demands that might not magically ease off even if they choose never to pick up the bottle. "In uncertain times, young people are experiencing a huge amount of pressure to succeed and do well in their studies and careers," explains sociologist Dr Emily Nicholls, an expert in gender and alcohol consumption. "The decline in drinking is not a wholly positive thing if it's related in some ways to these pressures."



For Bronwen Thomas*, a 24-year-old teacher, Friday night consists of one or two beers and dinner after a sober week, before getting home early enough to be asleep by midnight. She believes her drinking life, or lack thereof, is shaped by the current world of work. "I'll spend one day of my weekend planning lessons or marking and I can't deal with a hangover on that day. The other day is my only time to do everything else: life admin and seeing friends and family," says Bronwen. She explains that, even among her friends who aren't so time-poor, low wages, high rents and large debts mean they're more conscious of where their disposable income is going. "My friends and I are mostly in graduate roles that don't pay well, and we're all broke for much of the month. Going out for food or to see a movie is often our one 'fun' part of the week, so we usually can't afford to buy wine on top of this."

Factor in, too, the number of millennials and gen Z-ers pursuing side hustles and you can see why polishing off a bottle of rosé in the name of #winwednesday seems like self-sabotage. "As a creative and entrepreneur, [giving up drinking] has been a massive part in the success of my endeavours," confirms Jaz Borri, a 26-year-old musician and "modern mystic" who quit booze six years ago. "Productivity is the biggest benefit. I'm able to be sharp, present and focused whenever I need to be."

* Beer fear

Put that way, sobriety feels like an entirely savvy move. But there's another, darker factor at play too. "I used to make an idiot out of myself when I was drunk," cringes corporate financier and non-drinker Samantha Lynch, 24. "The morning-after anxiety and stress were so bad, I'd begin to regret going out altogether. I'd spend the [next] week worrying."

It's a real concern for the under-30 quitters, who, according to La Trobe research, cited the impact alcohol had on their social experiences as their main reason for jumping on the wagon. While hangxiety – post-booze

paranoia – is something most of us have gone through, it's ramped up when your every move can be recorded then published online. "With phone cameras, selfie culture and the huge rise of social media, it's much easier to feel like you're always being judged and scrutinised," says Nicholls. "There's pressure to portray a certain image, which could be undermined by photos where you look out of control."

On the flip side, cutting out alcohol is likely to reduce anxiety – an often unexpected perk for new teetotalers. "When we drink, our brains block glutamate, which is responsible for anxiety, so we feel relaxed, but then when we go to sleep, our brains get to work producing more glutamate to compensate," explains Leo. "It means the next day you can feel even more anxious. Many people who drink frequently are really surprised that when they stop, they start to feel calmer and more relaxed."

* Changing pace

There's no doubt that the health implications of the sobriety trend could be significant. More than 150,000 Australians are hospitalised each year due to alcohol harm, and the societal cost of alcohol abuse is estimated to be a staggering \$36 billion every year. If younger generations continue cutting back, their risk of developing certain cancers, heart disease, liver disease, brain damage or damage to the nervous system and having a stroke – all of which can and do befall heavy drinkers – will be reduced.

While the threat of social media shaming and pressure to compete in the workplace are worrying drivers, there's one underlying shift that deserves applause: Australia's drinking culture finally seems to be maturing. "Incentives like Hello Sunday Morning, Dry July and FebFast have made it socially acceptable to refuse a drink," says Leo. "Being more educated about mental health and risks, as well as a greater focus on wellbeing, mean that most people these days will understand if someone chooses not to drink." Going your own way at the bar, minus the peer pressure? We'll raise a (zero-proof) toast to that.